

MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

THE NEW SONG
A veena at Lata Mangeshkar Chowk, now a selfie point

the biggest Hindu pilgrimage site —"on the lines of the Vatican and the Mecca". The expected pilgrim throng at Ayodhya, which already clocked three quarters of a million in the first two days after the consecration ceremony, is drawing enthused analogies with the Haj. This is a bundle of metaphors that has come to be widely adopted, whose irony is not limited to the fact that, for one, the Vatican is not associated in any way with the life of Christ, only with the power of the Church. Commentators have not missed the tilt towards what they are calling "*ekeshwarvaad*", a monotheistic strain reminiscent of the Abrahamic faiths. It's a form of conceptual echophenomenon in plain sight. A belief system emulating and adopting the characteristics of the very thing it sees as the enemy. Except that Ram is the singularity at its centre. A figure given to us as the sole defining divinity of India, sprung from a Ramayana story that has come to be seen as mapping the modern nation's very territory. Alluding to one of the many voices rhapsodising in this vein, Sonia Sikka, a professor at the University of Ottawa who specialises in the Philosophy of Religion, wrote on X: "Vatican City, Mecca. The British did its job well, it seems. The semitisation of Hinduism is complete."

It is clearly not just a city that is being rebuilt. Think of organic Hinduism, complete with its beauty and its warts, as a map. It is an immense continent, teeming with the life of a forest—not a neat urban grid. All roads do not lead to Ram. Even if not fully exhaustive, a 2022 study by a group in IIT Bombay counted only 16 temples per one lakh population in UP. By contrast, Tamil Nadu had 103, India's highest score. But many of those deities may be unrecognisable in Mainpuri or Gonda. Kerala had a high score of 64 per lakh population, but out of its total of 22,931 temples, only 22 had Rama as the deity; most are place-specific Bhagawathy temples. In the ever-evolving landscape of Pauranic devotion, we are at a juncture where Vaishnavism has won many sectarian battles with its integrative, cooptive gestures but the Saiva and Shakta streams retain their gravitational fields for millions. This living Hinduism defies definition except as a vast, heaving polyphonic sea, bound by no one scripture, no Church, no central authority, and with heterodoxy in its very gene code. Even its philosophies exist as refutations of each other—as much as attempts to integrate. All of Vedanta reaches for the Absolute, but it is Formless for Adi Sankara, and he does not favour idol-based *bhakti* for its own sake. Ramanuja pivots to *bhakti* as the primary mode. In a mirror reflection, Kabir's Ram is a near-Vedantic abstraction, but it's the *saguna* Ram of Tulsidas that has proved more seminal. The accidents of politics, of course, are not indebted to either philosophy or theology—its patriarchs are ecumenical. But the new temple is in some ways also the consummation of older tendencies; and the new Ayodhya, filtered through the agonistic consciousness of a modern political project, aspires to the status of a theological capital.

The poet Iqbal had famously, and adoringly, singled out the god-king of Ayodhya as the "Imam-e-Hind" in 1908, during his 'secular' phase—a phrase quoted often on all sides. The British colonial enthusiasm for Tulsidas's *Ramcharitmanas* offers more layers for examination. This was the text that all historians agree set the template for Hindi/Hindu-centred nationalism, putting Ram on the lips of everyone right up to Gandhi and lending a new primacy to Ayodhya. In 1930, the Orientalist scholar J.M. Macfie called it "the Bible of Northern India". Decades before, the translator F.S. Growse, who spent decades in Uttar Pradesh as a civil servant in the 19th century, wrote that it was "a passionate protest against the virtual atheism of philosophical Hindu thought". Following in his wake, Grierson said Tulsidas had "saved the country from the tantric obscenities of Saivism". The figure of Rama—pious, stoic, not given to excess—obviously touched a deep Christian chord in them. Grierson, in fact, proposed that the Vaishnavism of Ramanuja was inspired by his proximity to the St Thomas Mount in Chennai. Krishna and Rama veneration did indeed develop very strong monotheistic trends in nearly all Vaishnava *sampradayas*—they became Swayam Bhagavan, self-born and supreme godhead. Maybe the colonial scholars were in exuberant folly, but those who would say so most ardently are the ones who actually follow in their wake. The millions who come to Ayodhya this season onwards may or may not make the same leap of faith. ■